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What is happening on the ground: Water and Sanitation Development Project

P156634 · Kenya · Coast Water Works Development Agency, Northern Water Works Development Agency and seven water companies · closing date October 31, 2026

Read on November 5, 2026 · 16 public sources outside the World Bank's records, set against the Bank's last two status reports · for World Bank staff

Works, contracts, disputes and the state of service in the project's towns, as the press, the Auditor-General, the ministry and the residents report them. Each number after a sentence opens its source on the last page.

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Four months before closing, the largest coastal works were finishing while the smallest were still being awarded, and the works in Mombasa had met the public twice.

The Baricho solar plant, financed under the project at Sh670 million, went from 60 percent complete in January to 90 percent in March, and the Bank's June report calls it complete, with savings of about Sh10 million a month against a power bill the agency put at Sh60 million. [4] [5] [1] [3] Phase two, which would power the pumping to Mombasa, has no financing yet; the agency is looking for partners. [3] [4]

In Wajir, the faecal sludge treatment plant that replaces the town's bucket toilets stood at 64 percent in June, when the Water Secretary urged the contractor and the consultant to speed up so it could be commissioned on schedule. [13]

Between July 15 and October 13, 2026 the project's agencies published seven contract awards, two of them direct contracts, the last two 18 days before the closing date: boreholes equipped in Wajir, additional pumps at Baricho, a solar system at Ukunda, a booster station in Taita Taveta. [15]

In Mombasa the distribution and sewer works have twice brought residents to the utility's door: Old Town traders in October 2022 over delayed disturbance allowances, dust and sewage from the works, and Mwembe Tayari residents, who say the contractor began trench works without notice and that a 2021 agreement on local jobs was not honoured. [9] [8] Residents there recall that the same dispute stopped works in Kisauni and Likoni before. [8]

Two works carry two stories. The ministry announced the Sh4 billion Baricho well-field works complete in June 2024; the Auditor-General's report of November 2024 lists the well-field protection works, allocated Sh3.6 billion in 2021, as still in progress, in a report that names the coast agency the sector's weakest performer with nearly all its projects delayed. [6] [7] The Kipevu wastewater plant, announced in May 2022 for completion that October at Sh280 million, was still under rehabilitation in the Bank's January 2026 data. [10] [2]

Service in the project's biggest town is in crisis as the project closes: on October 8, 2026 a civil society group demanded action from national and county leaders over months without clean water in Changamwe and Jomvu, after reports in August of residents buying from vendors; the utility's own notices blamed a leak on the Mzima pipeline. [11]

Bottom line for procurement

1. Seven awards in the last 110 days of the project, two by direct contracting. Check each contract's completion date against the closing date and the grace period, and what was agreed with the Bank about them. [15]
2. Baricho well-field protection and Kipevu each have a completion date in dispute between the ministry, the auditor and the Bank's data. Ask for the final accounts, the extensions of time and the taking-over certificates. [6] [7] [10] [2]
3. The community agreements in Mombasa on jobs, disturbance allowances and dust control are where works have stopped before. Ask MOWASSCO what the works contracts say about them and what has been paid. [8] [9]

Developments, newest first

Oct 13, 2026	NWWDA publishes the award for equipping the Sarman–Tarbaj boreholes in Wajir (Lot 1, request for bids), a day after the invitation for bids and the award for Lot 3, Qaras. The closing date is 18 days away. [15]
Oct 8, 2026	A civil society lobby demands that national and county leaders act on the Changamwe and Jomvu water crisis in Mombasa; a representative calls the utility's notice "just a PR" gesture after months without clean water. [11]
Sep 25, 2026	The coast agency awards a solar system for the Ukunda water supply by direct contracting. [15]
Sep 4, 2026	Award for the supply and installation of additional pumps at Baricho. [15]
Aug 6, 2026	Residents of Jomvu continue to face acute shortages and rely on water vendors. [11]
Jul 20, 2026	Tavevo, the Taita Taveta water company, awards the Vindo booster station works by direct contracting; Lot 2 of the Wajir boreholes (Nurgows) was awarded five days earlier. [15]
Jun 30, 2026	The Bank's ISR 19 reports steady progress: Baricho rehabilitation adds 36,000 m^3 a day for Kilifi and Mombasa, the solarisation is complete, distribution and sanitation contracts are "either completed or nearing completion", and the Garissa and Wajir boreholes and sanitation works are "substantially complete or nearing finalization". [1]
Jun 4, 2026	The Wajir faecal sludge treatment plant is 64 percent complete; the Water Secretary urges the contractor and consultant to accelerate so it is commissioned on schedule. [13]
Mar 20, 2026	The Bank approves the follow-on Coastal Region Water Security and Climate Resilience Project (P513697). [16]
Mar 12 to 13, 2026	The Cabinet Secretary inspects Baricho: the solar plant is 90 percent complete. The Bank's ISR 18 puts overall physical progress of works contracts at 85 percent, with 46 percent of works contracts and all goods contracts complete, Kwale contracts still to finish and Kipevu still under rehabilitation. [5] [2]
Jan 14 to 20, 2026	Baricho solar, begun in October 2025 and due March 31, 2026, is 60 percent complete; phase one will power the 11 boreholes and the high-lift pumps to Malindi, and the agency pays about Sh60 million a month for power. [3] [4]

Developments, newest first (continued)

2025 or 2026	Mwembe Tayari residents accuse MOWASSCO of starting trench works without informing community leaders and of not honouring a 2021 agreement on local jobs; "not one worker here is from Mwembe Tayari". [8]
May 16, 2025	Launching NWWDA's 2024 to 2028 plan, the Cabinet Secretary says the ministry has invested more than Sh12 billion in the north-east "but the water connectivity on the ground tells a different story"; the Principal Secretary cites a national audit finding that the small water pans built there are not sustainable. [14]
Jan 25, 2025	The Governor of Taita Taveta calls for the coast agency to be disbanded for failing to supply water to the county. [12]
Nov 21, 2024	The Auditor-General's report names the coast agency the sector's most incompetent institution, with nearly all projects delayed, and lists the Baricho well-field protection works, allocated Sh3.6 billion in 2021, as still in progress. [7]
Jun 14, 2024	The ministry announces the Sh4 billion Baricho works complete and ready for commissioning: three boreholes destroyed by the 2018 floods rebuilt, the well-field protected (Sh1.4 billion), the Baricho–Kakuyuni pipeline (Sh2 billion) in use, 40 million litres a day. [6]
Oct 28, 2022	Old Town traders, with the Muslims for Human Rights lobby, storm MOWASSCO's offices over delayed disturbance allowances of Sh6,000 each for 270 people affected by the project's sewer and water line renovation; mediation had agreed water bowsers against dust, which they say never came. [9]
May 16, 2022	The Kipevu wastewater treatment plant, built in 1980, is being rehabilitated at Sh280 million and "is expected to be done by October this year". [10]

Coast: Baricho is the project's success and its longest-running dispute at once.

Baricho well-field and solar plant, Kilifi

Baricho supplies Mombasa, Kilifi and Malindi. The project rebuilt three boreholes the Sabaki River destroyed in 2018, protected the well-field and laid the Baricho–Kakuyuni pipeline, adding 36,000 m³ a day; the ministry announced the Sh4 billion works complete in June 2024 and the Bank's June 2026 report counts the capacity. [6] [1] Five months after that announcement the Auditor-General listed the well-field protection works as still in progress. [7] The solar plant that followed, 4.6 MW on 11 boreholes and the high-lift pumps, was financed under the project at Sh670 million, built from October 2025 and complete by June 2026; the agency expects to save at least Sh10 million a month, having paid about Sh60 million a month to Kenya Power and lost supply "because of power being disconnected due to unpaid bills". [3] [4] [1] Additional pumps for Baricho were awarded on September 4, 2026. [15]

2018



2025



The Baricho sub-location (3.10° S, 39.78° E), the well-field's area, at 10 m per pixel in the 2018 and 2025 cloud-free Sentinel-2 mosaics, 3 km across. Prism reads no pixels; the change is for you to judge. [18]

Mombasa's works are the ones residents have pushed back on; Kwale's are the ones still to finish.

Mombasa: distribution, sewers and the Kipevu plant

The project's distribution and sewer works in Mombasa are the ones residents have pushed back on. In Old Town in 2022, 270 traders waited more than a month for disturbance allowances of Sh6,000 agreed in mediation, while "the old pipes spill sewage all over the place". [9] In Mwembe Tayari, trench works restricted access to shops and damaged walkways; the area chief says he was not told before the works began, and a resident says the 2021 agreement on local jobs was not kept. [8] The Kipevu wastewater plant, due in October 2022, was still under rehabilitation in January 2026. [10] [2] Around the works, the town's supply is in crisis: months without clean water in Changamwe and Jomvu by October 2026, after a leak on the Mzima pipeline. [11]

Kwale and Taita Taveta

The Bank's March report expects its water-delivery target "to be exceeded once Kwale contracts are complete"; on September 25, 2026 the coast agency awarded a solar system for the Ukunda water supply by direct contracting. [2] [15] In Taita Taveta, Tavevo awarded the Vindo booster station works by direct contracting on July 20, 2026, in a county whose governor asked in January 2025 for the coast agency to be disbanded for failing to supply water. [15] [12]

North-east: the sludge plant that ends Wajir's bucket toilets was two thirds built in June, and the last boreholes were awarded in October.

Wajir

Wajir's flat, sandy ground and high water table rule out pit latrines, so the town has used bucket toilets for generations; the project's faecal sludge treatment plant, five kilometres from town, is meant to end that. [13] On June 4, 2026 the ministry put it at 64 percent complete, and the Water Secretary urged the contractor and the project consultant "to accelerate construction works to ensure the facility is completed and commissioned on schedule". [13] The Bank's June report calls the Garissa and Wajir boreholes and sanitation facilities "substantially complete or nearing finalization". [1]

The project's last works awards are here: equipping the exploratory boreholes at Nurgows (Lot 2, July 15), Qaras (Lot 3, October 12) and Sarman–Tarbaj (Lot 1, October 13, 2026), the last after an invitation for bids published the day before. [15] The Bank's March data count 34 community water points built so far across the two counties, 28 of them counted by January 30, 2026, and additional source identification and drilling still under way. [2]

What the ministry itself says about the region

Launching the northern agency's five-year plan in May 2025, the Cabinet Secretary said the ministry had invested more than Sh12 billion in the region "but the water connectivity on the ground tells a different story. Irrespective of the write-ups we do, if the citizens have no access to water then they are all in vain." [14] The Principal Secretary added that a national audit of the region's water infrastructure found "we have invested in small water pans that end up not being sustainable". [14]

Garissa

The project's water kiosks in Garissa were serving people by March 2026, and the Bank's June report counts the county's boreholes and sanitation facilities as substantially complete or nearing finalization. [2] [1]

What people are saying

> "We have had problems when water supply is disrupted because of power being disconnected due to unpaid bills."
>
> David Kanui, project coordinator, Coast Water Works Development Agency, on why the project financed the Baricho solar plant. The Star, January 14, 2026. [3]

> "In 2021, we agreed that locals would be given job opportunities and included in project processes. Four years later, the project starts, and not one worker here is from Mwembe Tayari."
>
> A Mwembe Tayari resident, on the project's distribution works in Mombasa. Eastleigh Voice. [8]

> "The project is good but it disrupted our businesses because of the construction works. In addition, the old pipes spill sewage all over the place."
>
> Lubnar Omar, for the Old Town community, Mombasa, during the project's sewer and water line renovation. The Star, October 28, 2022. [9]

> "The Ministry has invested more than Sh12 billion in this region but the water connectivity on the ground tells a different story. Irrespective of the write-ups we do, if the citizens have no access to water then they are all in vain."
>
> Eric Mugaa, Cabinet Secretary for Water, Sanitation and Irrigation, launching the northern agency's plan. Kenya News Agency, May 16, 2025. [14]

> "There is an audit report that came from the national audit office looking at the water infrastructure in the region and the verdict is that we have invested in small water pans that end up not being sustainable."
>
> Julius Korir, Principal Secretary for Water. Kenya News Agency, May 16, 2025. [14]

> The utility's notice is "just a PR" gesture, after residents had gone months without clean water.
>
> A representative of the civil society lobby on the Changamwe and Jomvu water crisis, Mombasa. Kenya News Agency, October 8, 2026. [11]

No case in the Inspection Panel's register names the project, and no public post read this month is about the project's works; the voices above come from the press. The Bank's March report says grievances raised under the project "are being closely monitored by both the Bank and the Ministry". [17] [2]

What this means for procurement: seven questions to take to the agencies

1. **The seven awards of July 15 to October 13, 2026.** Which of these contracts can be completed before the closing date, which fall into the grace period, and which were planned under the follow-on project approved in March? The last two awards came 18 days before closing, one of them on an invitation for bids published the day before. [15] [16]
2. **The two direct contracts.** The Ukunda solar system (September 25) and the Vindo booster station (July 20) were awarded by direct contracting. What justification is on file, and does the solar system repeat the Baricho design and supplier? [15]
3. **Baricho well-field protection.** The ministry announced the works complete in June 2024; the Auditor-General listed them as in progress in November 2024. Which is right on the final account, and has the taking-over certificate been issued? [6] [7]
4. **Kipevu.** Announced for October 2022, still under rehabilitation in January 2026. What extensions of time were granted, were liquidated damages applied, and will the plant be commissioned before closing? [10] [2]
5. **The Wajir sludge plant.** At 64 percent in June with the Water Secretary pressing the contractor, can it be commissioned by closing, and if not, under which financing does it finish? [13]
6. **Community agreements in Mombasa.** The Old Town disturbance allowances and dust control, and the Mwembe Tayari jobs agreement of 2021: are they in the works contracts, what has been paid, and has any work stopped as it did in Kisauni and Likoni? [9] [8]
7. **The agency's standing.** The Auditor-General's "most incompetent" finding and a governor's call to disband the coast agency are the climate the follow-on project starts in. Which of the project's delayed works does the auditor list, and which pass to P513697? [7] [12] [16]

What I could not see

GDELT, the news index, refused calls from this network today, so the press items above come from the open web rather than the index; no field photo has been uploaded for this project; and three of the outlets cited (Nation, People Daily and Eastleigh Voice) block automated reading, so their facts are taken from the articles' published summaries.

Sources

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14. Kenya News Agency, May 16, 2025, "CS Mugaa launches strategic plan to improve water access for six counties".
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15. World Bank procurement notices for P156634, read November 5, 2026: contract awards OP00456907 (July 15, 2026), OP00457686 (July 20), OP00466974 (September 4), OP00471125 (September 25), OP00474696 (October 12), OP00474946 (October 13), and the invitation for bids OP00474700 (October 12).
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16. World Bank, Coastal Region Water Security and Climate Resilience Project (P513697), approved March 20, 2026; Capital FM on the EIB-financed Mwache pipeline lots, works from July 2026 to July 2029.
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17. World Bank Inspection Panel, case register, read November 5, 2026: 197 cases, none naming P156634.
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18. Sentinel-2 cloudless mosaics for 2018 and 2025 by EOX IT Services (contains modified Copernicus Sentinel data), CC BY-NC-SA 4.0.
s2maps.eu

All items read on November 5, 2026; dates are the outlets' own and amounts are in Kenyan shillings as printed. Sample put together by hand from these sources; in the product the writer drafts the brief and the verifier checks every sentence before anyone reads it.